

Luleå University of Technology CoARA Action Plan

2025-05-20

Luleå University of Technology is the northernmost university in Sweden, renowned for its groundbreaking research in close collaboration with external partners. Originally established as a technical college in 1971, it was granted full university status in 1997. The university offers a broad range of research and educational programs spanning engineering, social sciences, business administration, health, teacher education, and music and theatre. Our scientific and artistic research and education are carried out in close cooperation with international, national, and regional companies, the public sector, and leading universities. Luleå University of Technology has approximately 1,900 employees and hosts over 18,700 students. Interdisciplinary research is central to our work, and the university fosters an inclusive culture built on courage, openness, and trust.

Luleå University of Technology (henceforth LTU) joined the Coalition of Advancing Research Assessment (CoARA) in June 2024 by signing the Agreement on Reforming Research Assessment (ARRA).¹ LTU has thus committed to ARRA and its four core commitments:

- 1) Recognise the diversity of contribution to, and careers in, research in accordance with the needs and nature of the research
- 2) Base research assessment primarily on qualitative evaluation for which peer review is central, supported by responsible use of quantitative indicators
- 3) Abandon inappropriate uses in research assessment of journal- and publication-based metrics, in particular inappropriate uses of Journal Impact Factor (JIF) and h-index
- 4) Avoid the use of rankings of research organisations in research assessment.

Our expectations and ambitions are that ARRA and CoARA will contribute to the development of LTU as a modern and transparent university that honours and values fair and equal merit assessments and this is expected to strengthen both research quality and impact. Furthermore, our work with ARRA will contribute to alignment with the newly adopted open science guidelines by The National Library of Sweden: “A prerequisite for a successful implementation of the guidelines is that open science receives attention and becomes meritorious in the contexts where researchers, individually or in larger constellations, as well as research performing organizations are evaluated and assessed².”

¹ https://coara.eu/app/uploads/2022/09/2022_07_19_rra_agreement_final.pdf

² <https://urn.kb.se/resolve?urn=urn:nbn:se:kb:publ-738>

The aim of this document is to share with the signatories of ARRA how we have started the process of reviewing and developing our current practises to better align with the core commitments.

Action plan

To develop our practices and strengthen our research, the following action plan for 2025-2029 will be implemented. Our ambition is to make use of existing processes and ongoing quality improvement efforts when aligning to CoARA principles, a key feature is to raise awareness and discuss good practices. Leadership for this initiative will be provided by the Pro Vice-Chancellor, and the Vice-Chancellor's Research Council will act as the steering committee. The university library is responsible for coordinating the efforts.

Planned activities

1. GAP-analysis

In 2025, an internal GAP analysis was initiated to identify discrepancies between the CoARA commitments and current practices at LTU. This analysis highlighted key areas for implementation of CoARA principles, these form the basis of the current action plan. However, continued analysis is needed to guide the work and priorities ahead.

2. Highlighting and promoting CoARA internally

Information about CoARA's core commitments and the university's action plan will be communicated and discussed broadly and with key stakeholders to raise awareness and support implementation at all levels. This work has been initiated by a general discussion and workshop at the university's strategy day in February 2025 and by posting information on the LTU website. During 2025–2026, a comprehensive communication strategy will be developed, alongside educational initiatives and activities, such as e.g. workshops, open educational resources etc. Special consideration will be given to the responsible use of bibliometrics, recognizing and highlighting its potential to support researchers and heads of subject by offering new insights into the development of their research.

3. Reviewing recruitment and promotion procedures

As the first university in Sweden, LTU was awarded the European Commission's HR Excellence in Research Award (HRS4R) in 2018 highlighting our commitment to ensure good working conditions, sound recruitment practices and good career development opportunities for researchers. Our compliance with HRS4R will be subject to external evaluation in 2025, which will be followed by a new GAP-analysis and action plan. As CoARA and HRS4R share common goals in improving research assessment and recruitment practices, the work with HRS4R will support the implementation of CoARA

at LTU. Special attention will also be given to the practical implementation of the university appointments procedure, for example by arranging workshops with the appointment boards.

4. Developing research assessments and ranking

LTU acknowledges a broad range of research outputs and activities when evaluating research and do not solely rely on quantitative indicators. Internal evaluation of research subjects includes self-evaluation by head of subjects to assess research quality coupled with a responsible use of sound indicators. The indicators are contextualized in the self-evaluation where head of subjects are encouraged to comment and reflect on all numerical data. In 2024 the set of indicators was revised to strengthen CoARA compliance by including a broader range of publication types when assessing research output and by introducing the mean-normalized citation score (MNCS). LTU does not use journal- and publication-based metrics such as Journal Impact Factor (JIF) and h-index for any decisions at central level.

LTU has also recently decided upon a new guideline for external evaluation of research subjects where peer-review is central. This guideline will be implemented during 2026 and evaluated thereafter.

LTU has decided on a more proactive approach in engaging in university rankings for recruitment and marketing purposes. However, this effort will be carefully balanced to ensure compliance with CoARA commitments. The university does not use rankings to promote or evaluate staff, no financial allocations are made based on rankings, and LTU has no intention of doing so in the future.

5. Continuing the transition towards open science

LTU endorse and support open science practices with a number of initiatives. We have an open access support in place to incentivize gold and diamond open access publishing by covering article processing charges. In addition, we recently launched LTU Drive which is secure research data storage and sharing solution. To support and facilitate the transition towards open and FAIR data we have data champions working in all departments, their role is to educate and advise their peers and to advocate for the importance of making data FAIR. The plan for the coming years is to continue increasing our open access publication rate and to boost the publication of research data, for example by placing greater emphasis on recognizing and rewarding early sharing and open collaboration.

6. Engaging in activities and knowledge sharing via the Swedish CoARA National Chapter

LTU's commitment to CoARA will be supported by engaging in the recently launched Swedish National Chapter. We will also consider joining CoARA working groups and

other similar initiatives supporting fair and equal research assessments. The university will encourage and support researchers to actively engage in knowledge sharing with others. The university has permanent representation in Brussels through our European Office, this resource will be able to monitor CoARA development on a European level.

The LTU CoARA action plan will be treated as a living document, subject to ongoing review and revision as needed.

Luleå University of Technology – assessment reform roadmap 2025-2029

2024	2025	2026	2027	2028	2029
Joining CoARA and signing the Agreement on Reforming Research Assessment	GAP analysis of CoARA compliance and submission of CoARA action plan	Continued GAP analysis and review of CoARA action plan	Review of CoARA action plan	Review of CoARA action plan	Review of CoARA action plan
	Raising awareness of CoARA at LTU	Raising awareness of CoARA at LTU	Raising awareness of CoARA at LTU	Raising awareness of CoARA at LTU	Raising awareness of CoARA at LTU
	Review of LTU's HRS4R award and potential review of the university's appointments procedure	New action plan for HRS4R	Implementation of HRS4R action plan	Implementation of HRS4R action plan	Implementation of HRS4R action plan
Revision of guidelines for evaluation of research subjects, including CoARA compliance	Introduction of a revised set of indicators	Pilot of new model for external review of research subjects	Evaluation of the pilot		
Strengthen open science commitment, including introduction of open access support and data champions	Continued development of open access commitment, including development of open science policy and data champion scheme	Continued transition towards open science	Continued transition towards open science	Continued transition towards open science	Continued transition towards open science
		Engaging with the Swedish National Chapter	Consider joining CoARA working groups	Continued engagement	Continued engagement